

7 Dark Psychology Tactics

A field guide to the patterns running quietly in the background of your everyday conversations.

You won't find dramatic villains in this guide. No con artists, no movie-style manipulators. Just patterns — small, repeatable, and usually invisible to the person using them, including you. Once you can name a pattern, you start noticing it everywhere. That's the point.

TACTIC 1

The Foot-in-the-Door

Someone asks you for something small. You agree — it's easy, it's reasonable. Then they ask for something bigger. You say yes again, because you've already started saying yes. Compliance isn't usually one decision. It's momentum, and the first yes is the one that counts.

TACTIC 2

Anchoring

The first number you hear becomes the reference point for every number after it. A \$200 price tag makes \$120 feel like a bargain — even if \$120 was always too much. Your brain isn't comparing the price to your budget. It's comparing it to the first thing it saw.

TACTIC 3

The Reciprocity Trap

Someone does something small for you — a favor, a gift, an unsolicited compliment. Now you feel like you owe them. You didn't agree to this debt. You inherited it the moment you accepted, and most people repay it without ever questioning why.

TACTIC 4

Social Proof

You look around before you decide. If everyone else is doing it, it must be fine. This is how lines form, how trends spread, and how entire rooms of reasonable people end up making the same bad decision at the same time.

TACTIC 5

Scarcity

"Only 3 left." "Offer ends tonight." The moment something feels limited, your brain stops calculating value and starts calculating loss. And loss — even imagined, even manufactured — moves faster than logic.

TACTIC 6

Gaslighting

The slow rewriting of your memory by someone else's confidence. "That never happened." "You're remembering it wrong." Said often enough, by someone close enough, and you start to doubt the one witness you always trusted: yourself.

TACTIC 7

Confirmation Bias — The One You Use on Yourself

The first six are things people do to you. This one, you do to yourself, automatically, every day. Once you believe something, your brain quietly collects evidence that you're right — and discards anything that says otherwise. No one has to manipulate you for this one. You do it for free.

None of this is a reason to be paranoid. It's an invitation to be aware.

The researchers who mapped these patterns — Robert Cialdini, Daniel Kahneman, Martha Stout, Gavin de Becker — spent careers studying exactly how this works, and what to do once you can see it. Over the next couple weeks, you'll get a closer look at each one in your inbox.

Pay attention. You'll start seeing it everywhere.

— *The Mind Files*